

All the Didi's MEN

Mamata Banerjee has arrived with her army of Trinamool MPs. It's been teamwork all the way and the credit goes to her core group which helped script the success story.



AFP

By Abhijit Dasgupta

When the media, electronic or print, focuses on the Trinamool Congress (TMC), there are no group photographs. It's mainly the party's combative leader, Mamata Banerjee, who is the most seen and heard face of the party. If electoral success in E-2009 has only one mother in Bengal—after 32 years of Jyoti Basu and Buddhadeb Bhattacharya—she certainly deserves credit. But for anybody with a fleeting interest in Opposition politics in West Bengal, it has always been a singularly Mamata show, negative or positive. That, however, is not quite the truth. The lady, popularly referred to as 'Didi', does have an active core group which like

all political satraps works in close coordination and in a systematic manner, however centripetal the force may be. It is a well-known secret that Banerjee does not confide too much in too many, but she does need sounding boards and some people she can trust; a fact she learnt the hard way during the last five years when she was insulted, humiliated and cornered by MPs opposed to her in Parliament even as she tried to utter a few words on the floor of the House as the lone Trinamool MP. "You are alone", they used to poke fun at me... and even when I was finally given a chance to speak, it was qualified by a stern 'only a minute, please', rues Banerjee. Naturally, she is all vigour; her Bengal army now has 20 MPs—19 from Trinamool

BANERJEE (THIRD FROM LEFT) WITH HER WINNING TEAM

and one independent, a SUCI member supported by the TMC, who have made it their business to make what have now been proved: the right noises at the right time.

She has astutely ensured that her core group has not been touched even as she begins packing for Delhi. Among the 20 MPs, only Dinesh Trivedi of her core group, who is well-versed in Delhi politics, is heading for the capital. He knows the nuances of parliamentary behaviour, having been a Rajya Sabha member before and has achieved the impossible by defeating CPI(M) stalwart Tarit Topdar in the Left's bastion, Barrackpore, near Kolkata. "I first got to hear of her